Mann called for the National Security and Defence Council, the highest executive body overseeing security affairs of the state, to coordinate on the peace process with the executive (Pyithu Hluttaw 2013). In its 2014–15 budget proposal, the executive was praised for allocating US$7 million for the peace process (Yen Snaing 2014). But it was the Hluttaw that had sought funding for the peace process a year earlier, squeezing it from unimportant projects (Pyidaungsu Hluttaw 2013).[4] There were extensive informal consultations between ethnic lawmakers and the military representatives, as both were involved directly or indirectly in the borderland conflict.[5]

While it was highly non-partisan and received most support from the speakers and lawmakers, the first motion on peace was rejected, for two reasons: (i) the Hluttaw overwhelmingly controlled by the USDP did not want to undermine its president who announced his peace initiative a few days later;[6] and (ii) the Hluttaw was reluctant to accept motions from non-USDP parties in the early days. Amid renewed conflict in Kachin State in 2013, the Hluttaw also adopted four motions on ending conflict in Kachin State but to no avail. In the meantime, the government formed the UPCC and UPWC on 19 May 2012. Prominent ethnic legislators from the ruling and ethnic parties were included as members (President's Office 2012).[7] On the other hand, Union Minister U Aung Min facilitated by the Myanmar Peace Centre (MPC) did most of the nitty-gritty work (see Su Mon Thazin Aung, this volume). Participation of ethnic legislators in the UPWC was largely ceremonial. The Hluttaw has its own peace committee but its involvement in the peace process was again notional rather than substantial.[8] As U Hkyet Hting Nan from the Amyotha Hluttaw explained:

> In the beginning, ethnic armed group representatives did not trust us and saw us as collaborators of the ruling party and its government. Though these perceptions are diminishing, we still have limitations in participating in the peace process. The government not the Hluttaw is leading the talks. But the Hluttaw is ultimately responsible for legitimizing the whole peace process. Therefore, I am happy to be part of it.[9]

While his presence legitimized the process, he seemed frustrated with his inability to influence the dialogue substantively, because there was no major role for a legislator to play. Most of the negotiations were dealt with directly by the military and the executive.

Ethnic legislators — except for a few prominent ones who had come from ethnic armed groups — were not confident in participating in the peace process. EAG members had direct or indirect connections with the